finally a phone call from Hardeep Bhaiya, Dad's buddy, which made me believe it all. In all this activity, report-writing was forgotten, and we had a hectic day later in the week to meet the deadline. 31 December was the day Popsi officially took over with the handing over of the Command Baton marking the occasion. The ceremony itself is very low-key with not much pomp and splendour attached to it. We were all there; Mom, me, Simon, Sonutai, Mukund Daddy, and Dad's first CO, Brig Madan Das, as well as the first 2iC, Brig JS Kanwar. In all this excitement, I sorely missed Amala. Life has not materially changed for us. The real challenge lies ahead—how to snatch moments of quality time with each other.

Life though, did change for all of us, right from being put in the Z+ protected category. There was no personal life or impromptu programmes any more. All events had to be planned well in advance. Just 'dropping in' at a friend's place for dinner was out of the question. Any location that had to be visited had to be sanitized in advance by a bomb detection or dog squad. We had police escorts to the front and rear, plus a close protection group drawn from the elite Special Forces of the Army. The ADC (Security), Maj Bhojpal Shakya, had his hands full coordinating each move and event like a master choreographer. We also became mini-celebrities, with everyone wanting to take selfies with us. We instantly began to sympathize and identify with celebrities who are hounded by paparazzi. I remember that on one occasion, it was a wedding, and the photographer kept following us around, clicking away merrily. Finally, Veena had to intervene and tell him to go take snaps of the bride and groom, whose wedding it was. As Vice-Chief, I had seen this happening with General and Mrs Rawat, but experiencing this kind of attention first-hand was

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